

1. Can you describe your role in relation to the student research projects you have been involved in or supervised?

I am involved in student research projects primarily as a program manager and researcher. Within Value Chain Hackers, my role is to ensure overall continuity and coherence across projects, across cohorts, and across years. This includes aligning student work with longer-term research agendas, external partnerships, and institutional requirements.

I also supervise and guide students during internships and applied research projects, with a focus on helping them translate exploratory work into outputs that can be communicated, assessed, and, where possible, reused.

2. At the start of projects, what guidance are students typically given about how they are expected to document their research work? Can you give an example?

At the start of projects, students are informed that documentation is a necessary part of applied research, both for academic accountability and for continuity across project cycles. This includes producing a clear final report, storing materials centrally, and making sources and methods explicit.

Documentation is framed as part of professional research practice, particularly because projects may feed into publications, funding accountability, or legal and institutional obligations.

3. Can you describe specific situations where documentation came up during project work with students? What happened in those moments?

Documentation often becomes particularly relevant at transition points. For example, when a project is handed over to a new group of students, or when results need to be reviewed for publication or external reporting.

In those moments, it becomes clear which parts of the work are sufficiently documented to stand on their own, and which parts rely heavily on verbal explanation or personal memory.

4. Based on the final outputs of projects, how usable do you think they are for someone new who has not spoken to the original student team? Can you give an example?

The usability of final outputs varies. In many cases, reports provide a solid overview of the topic and the conclusions reached, which is valuable for orientation.

However, for someone who wants to build directly on the work, additional clarification is often needed. This is one of the reasons why structured documentation and publication-ready outputs are important: they reduce dependency on the original team.

5. Which parts tend to be difficult for someone new to understand based only on what is written down or stored?

What is often difficult to reconstruct are the intermediate steps. This includes how research questions evolved, how data limitations were handled, and how methodological choices were made under practical constraints.

These aspects are understandable within the educational context, but they do limit reuse if they are not made explicit.

6. Can you think of an example of an important decision or change during a project, and describe how and where it was documented, if at all?

A common example is a shift in scope once students encounter feasibility issues, such as limited access to data or stakeholders. These shifts are usually discussed with supervisors and reflected in the final framing of the project.

In some cases, the rationale for these changes is captured in reports or reflection sections, but not always in a way that is easily traceable for future users.

7. If someone new wanted to understand how one important conclusion of a project was reached, what would they need to look at or read?

They would need the final report, access to the datasets or sources used, and a clear description of the analytical approach. When these elements are present and well-structured, it becomes much easier to assess and reuse the work.

This is particularly important when research outputs are intended for publication or longer-term use.

8. During projects, is it clear who is responsible for documenting what, if anyone? How is that responsibility typically communicated or decided?

Responsibility for documentation is generally shared among students, with supervisors providing guidance and feedback. There is usually no single person formally assigned as documentation owner.

This works reasonably well for educational purposes, but it does create variability in how consistently documentation is handled across projects.

9. What tools, templates, or systems are students expected to use to document work, and where is everything actually stored in practice?

Students use a range of tools, including shared drives, reports, spreadsheets, and collaborative platforms. Templates are sometimes provided, particularly for reports or publications, to ensure a minimum level of consistency.

Storage is typically centralised, but the structure and completeness of project archives can differ from one project to another.

10. What do you think the purpose of documentation is in these projects? Who do you think benefits from it, if anyone? And what, if anything, influences how motivated students are to document their work well?

Documentation serves several purposes. It supports assessment, enables publication, meets legal and institutional requirements, and helps ensure continuity across student cohorts.

Students are generally more motivated to document their work when they see that it has a concrete purpose beyond grading, for example when it contributes to a publication, a follow-up project, or a real external deliverable.

11. Based on your experience, what tends to get lost most often over time across projects?

What tends to be lost is contextual knowledge: why certain compromises were made, how constraints shaped decisions, and what was learned informally during the process.

This is one of the challenges of working with student-led projects that have a limited timeframe.

12. How does documentation generally fit into project work from your perspective? Does it seem integrated into the work, or more like something added on top? Why?

Documentation is partially integrated, but it often becomes more prominent toward the end of projects. This reflects the reality of applied education, where students are balancing learning, experimentation, and deliverables within a fixed timeframe.

Ideally, documentation would be more evenly distributed throughout the project lifecycle.

13. From your perspective, what currently makes it difficult to achieve consistent documentation across projects?

The main difficulty lies in the educational context itself. Projects are short, student experience levels vary widely, and learning objectives are often prioritised over long-term continuity.

As a result, documentation quality depends heavily on guidance, templates, and institutional support structures rather than individual motivation alone.

14. Is there anything about documentation, continuity, or research practice that we have not discussed but that you think is important?

It is important to be realistic about what student research can achieve. Not every project will produce outputs that are directly reusable.

However, by focusing on clear documentation, publication-oriented outputs, and stable project structures, we can gradually build a body of work that supports both education and longer-term research objectives.